

EV Industry in Uganda — Strategic Research Report

Date: June 11, 2026
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Purpose: Strategic business planning for SyncSphere's East Africa engagement

1. Current State of EVs in Uganda

Adoption Numbers (2025)

Segment	Count	Notes
Electric motorcycles (e-bodas)	~3,000–3,200	<1% of Kampala's ~150,000 boda bodas
Electric buses	24	Kayoola EVS buses in GKMA
Electric cars (4W)	~17	Negligible
Total EVs	~3,000+	4th in East Africa (after Ethiopia 115K, Kenya 24.7K, Tanzania 10K)

Key Insight

Uganda is an **early-stage market**. EVs are barely penetrated. The dominant segment is electric motorcycles (e-bodas), not cars. This is the "two-wheelers first" pattern seen across East Africa.

2. Key Players

Domestic Manufacturing

- **Kiira Motors Corporation (KMC)** — Uganda's flagship EV company. Producing Kayoola EVS electric buses. Factory in Jinja Industrial Park. Capacity: 2,500 vehicles/year. Target: 500,000/year by 2030. Received UGX 32.5B government funding.
- **GOGO Electric** — E-motorcycle manufacturing + battery swapping. 75% of Li-ion battery value chain. Targeting 150,000 batteries/year by 2026. Received USD 3M from Uganda Development Bank.
- **Soleil Power** — First dedicated Li-ion pack assembly plant in East Africa. 14,000–20,000 batteries/year capacity.

Ride-Hailing & Fleet

- **SafeBoda** — Uganda's largest ride-hailing platform. Launched "Electric Boda" EV tier. Exited Nigeria to focus on Uganda profitability.
- **Zembo** — Electric boda-boda pioneer. Battery swapping at scale. Cross-border rides from Busia.
- **Spiro Uganda** — Reports growth from <1,000 to 4,000+ EV bodas in one year. Secured \$50M Afreximbank loan.
- **Bodawerk** — Local EV motorcycle company.

Charging Infrastructure

- **5 commercial charging stations** under development (as of 2024)
- **100+ battery swapping stations** operational (e-motorcycle focused)
- First public EV charging station launched April 2025 at Amber House, Kampala
- **Total** (French major) set up 13 EV charging stations

Financing

- **MOGO Uganda** — Leading EV financier. Financed 1,500+ electric motorcycles as of May 2025.
 - **Uganda Development Bank (UDB)** — Climate finance lines for e-mobility.
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3. Government Policy

National E-Mobility Strategy (2023)

- **Vision:** Full public transport & motorcycle electrification by 2030, passenger vehicle sales by 2040
- **7 strategic objectives:** Local manufacturing, battery production, public transport electrification, charging network, EV uptake, standards development, human capital
- **20-year roadmap** — positions Uganda as a net exporter of e-mobility solutions to Africa

Tax & Fiscal Incentives

- **Import duty:** 25% (reversed from zero-rated in mid-2024 — a setback)
- **VAT exemptions** on EVs and components
- **Stamp duty exemptions** for local manufacturers
- **Tax incentives** on charging and battery swapping services
- **Government fleet electrification** commitments

Regulatory

- Imported EVs must be ≤15 years old
- Euro 4 environmental standards
- 80% Ugandan employment & raw material sourcing target
- EAC standards harmonization

Key Concern

The reversal from zero-rated to 25% import duty in mid-2024 is a **significant policy setback** that increases EV costs. Stakeholders are pushing for restoration of incentives.

4. Charging Infrastructure

Current State

- **Grid:** 96% hydroelectric — one of the cleanest grids in Africa. This is Uganda's biggest competitive advantage for EVs.
- **Electricity access:** 57% national coverage (expanding)
- **Karuma Power Plant:** Commissioned 2024 — additional generation capacity
- **5 commercial charging stations** operational or under development

- **100+ battery swapping stations** (motorcycle-focused)
- **Solar-powered charging** along Kampala–Masaka corridor

Plans

- 2,000 mini-grids by 2030 (National Electrification Strategy)
- Urban + highway charging network
- Jinja Industrial Park as EV production hub

Bottleneck

Charging infrastructure is the **#1 barrier** to EV adoption. Outside Kampala and major corridors, coverage is minimal.

5. Market Opportunities

High-Potential Segments

1. **E-boda financing** — MOGO has proven the model. 1,500+ financed. Huge unmet demand (150,000+ petrol bodos in Kampala alone).
2. **Battery swapping infrastructure** — 100+ stations exist but need massive scaling. Pay-as-you-go model works.
3. **Electric bus assembly/manufacturing** — Kiira Motors is scaling. Government committed to public transport electrification by 2030.
4. **Local battery manufacturing** — GOGO and Soleil Power are early movers. Import substitution opportunity.
5. **Solar charging stations** — Uganda's hydro grid + solar = truly green charging. Exportable model.
6. **EV ride-hailing** — SafeBoda's EV tier is early but growing. Fleet electrification partnerships.
7. **Used EV imports** — Japan/Europe used EVs at 15-year age limit. Cost-effective entry point.

Investment Landscape

- **USD 100M+ invested** in Uganda e-mobility (2018–2024)
 - **70% government-funded** historically
 - **USD 800M private pipeline** projected
 - **Africa E-Mobility Report 2025:** 208 active companies across Africa, 98 in East Africa
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6. Barriers

Barrier	Severity	Detail
High upfront costs	Critical	EVs cost 2-3x more than petrol equivalents
Limited charging infrastructure	Critical	Outside Kampala, almost no coverage
Policy inconsistency	High	Import duty reversal in 2024 hurt confidence
Grid capacity outside cities	Medium	57% national electricity access
Limited financing options	Medium	MOGO is growing but undercapitalized
Skills gap	Medium	Need trained technicians for maintenance
Consumer awareness	Medium	Most Ugandans don't know EVs exist
Import dependency	High	Almost all EVs imported; local manufacturing nascent

7. Comparable Markets — East Africa Comparison

Country	Total EVs	% of Fleet	Policy Strength	Key Strength
Ethiopia	~115,000	~8%	★★★★★	Banned ICE imports; state-led
Rwanda	~5,500	~1.4%	★★★★★	Tax exemptions; restricted petrol boda registration
Kenya	~24,754	~0.5%	★★★☆☆	Market-driven; draft policy pending
Tanzania	~10,000 (2/3W)	Low	★★★☆☆	Highest 2/3W deployment
Uganda	~3,000	<0.1%	★★★☆☆	Clean grid; manufacturing base

Key Lessons

- **Ethiopia proves** state mandates work (banned ICE → 115K EVs)
- **Rwanda proves** targeted incentives work (restricted petrol bodas → rapid EV adoption)
- **Kenya shows** what happens without policy (innovation exists but scaling stalls)
- **Uganda's advantage:** 96% hydro grid + Kiira Motors manufacturing base + government commitment
- **Uganda's disadvantage:** Policy inconsistency (duty reversal), low electricity access outside cities

8. SyncSphere Relevance

Strategic Fit

Given SyncSphere's existing relationship with **Swangz Avenue Ltd** (Ugandan music label) and East Africa focus:

1. **Digital infrastructure for EV ecosystem** — SyncSphere deploys OSS tools (n8n, Listmonk, Plausible). These are directly applicable to:
2. EV fleet management platforms
3. Battery swapping payment/CRM systems
4. Charging station monitoring dashboards

5. EV ride-hailing backend services
6. **Website & digital presence** — Every Ugandan EV company (Kiira Motors, GOGO, Spiro, Zembo, SafeBoda) needs professional web presence. SyncSphere's web dev capability is immediately relevant.
7. **Social media management** — EV companies need brand building. SyncSphere's Marketing agent can serve this need.
8. **Regional play** — Uganda is the gateway to landlocked neighbors (South Sudan, DRC, Rwanda, Burundi). A successful Uganda engagement creates a beachhead.

Recommended Approach

- **Phase 1:** Offer digital services (web, social, automation) to existing Ugandan EV companies
- **Phase 2:** Build EV-specific SaaS tools (fleet management, charging station monitoring)
- **Phase 3:** Expand regionally using Uganda as the base

Caveat

This is a **long-term play**. Uganda's EV market is tiny today (<0.1% penetration). But the trajectory is clear: government commitment + clean grid + growing investment = significant opportunity in 3-5 years. Early positioning matters.

Sources

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